



Fortnite concert starring Ariana

Epic games has revealed a "Rift Tour" concert series that will star Ariana Grande. <https://digit.in/aug21-73>



Louis Vuitton's new mobile game

Louis Vuitton is making a mobile game with embedded NFTs. <https://digit.in/aug21-74>

Boo smartwatches

Why can't any of them work?

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he pandemic has changed us in many ways, and one of those ways is how we monitor health.

Fitness trackers used to be hot for gym-freaks and those crazy, rich people who cycle for fun, braving our traffic and inhaling the smog to keep, err..., healthy! Now we're all nervously checking SpO₂ levels every 15 minutes, especially if we catch a cold.

Theoretically, fitness trackers are supposed to send back data to the main device (usually your phone, unless you want to strap a tablet to your arm while you run). All data from all apps is aggregated by the OS' health module, HealthKit for Apple and Google Fit for Android. Being an iPhone user, this column is a little iOS centric, but my rant holds for all devices.

Apple users have the option of installing Google Fit as well, which was developed by the tech giant in collaboration with the World Health Organisation and the American Heart association. Android users cannot install HealthKit obviously.

The best device on the market is widely accepted to be the Apple Watch. It sucks! While it really is the best, it's kind of like being the best of the worst. The Apple Watch faces gallery is limited, and there are about five apps that work just right with the

complications (NapBot, Circadian, Carrot Weather, Heart Analyzer and Air Matters). Four of these require use of IAP and subscription services to work as intended, but there are no other options that work at all!

If you wanted FitBit or Goqii trackers, they each have their own competing ecosystems, and each work best with their own set of apps that work badly or not at all with the other smartwatch. Only a handful of apps, such as Rise, support pulling data from two different sources, such as HealthKit as well as Fitbit. There are problems with synchronisation, where the Fitbit app collects data all day, but the API updates it to HealthKit only once a day, and that too manually! Want it to happen automatically? That's a premium feature! Come on FitBit, do better! I don't even want to get started on the idiosyncrasies such as essential SpO₂ data only being synced in the night and shown to you the next day. Of course you need to install a special watch face to do even that!

The Goqii devices are cheaper, and while they sync well with the apps, and pull data from other apps

as well, the problem is reversed here! Very few third party apps can accept data from Goqii, which means innovative features such as body temperature monitoring are useless outside the Goqii app.

If you go any cheaper, you get an even worse experience. The River-song app, for example, claims to sync the data with HealthKit, but does not. The app makes no prompt to sync with HealthKit, and is not added as a data source inside HealthKit either, which is just barefaced lying.

Currently, smartwatches and smartbands seem to be a very sketchy experience with too many apps that do too little on their own. This kind of reminds me of the early days of computers, which was a lot of tinkering and fiddling with things, or even writing your own code to get things to work. The problem is that in this age of security paranoia, and lack of open source code, the terrible user experience is the same as the 80s, but with no tinkering possible! It does not need to be this way, if only someone would force collaboration instead of unhealthy competition.

Right now, there simply isn't a good smartwatch that integrates with a number of smartphone apps and a face gallery that does not get exhausted in a couple of scrolls.

This is something the whole world needs right now and the OEMs are just failing their customers. We can only hope this changes as the platform matures, but I had the optimism beaten out of me with experience, so don't hold your breath! (Which your FitBit will report as a low SpO₂ reading, but tomorrow, after you've passed out already!) 



They don't work like this!